Slaughter of the Meek

Bzzt…

Bzzt…

Bzzt…

I pulled my phone out of my pocket to check who was calling me on a Friday afternoon, a few hours before I was supposed to be off work. Tabitha.

Bzzt…

My sister and I had grown very close after she went off to college and came home shortly after dropping out, but over the past year, I have come to dread her calls. She is the bearer of bad news, when my parents are too preoccupied with the current situation, she is the one who calls me.

Bzzt…

I leave my desk and walk over to the privacy booth.

"Hey Taba,"

"Hey… It's Calvin… he…" I could hear her tears.

"Is he okay?"

"No, not really," she laughed through her sobs at the unrequited absurdity.

"What happened?"

"He… he had a heart attack."

"..."

"They resuscitated him, but he's in a coma and they haven't told us anything else."

I walk back to my desk and grab my things, before walking out the front door.

"I am on my way." I say.

"Mom and dad are on their way too, and I'm about to leave but you're the closest so you're gonna get there first."

"Okay."

"Do you want to talk about it?" she asks.

"Not right now. Just tell mom to call me when she gets the chance so she can tell me what to do when I get there."

"Are you sure you're okay to drive?"

"Yeah, I'll be fine. Don't worry about me. Are you gonna be okay driving?"

"Matt is gonna drive me."

'Good."

"I love you."

"I love you too."

Twenty-four years old. Less than two years older than me. What the fuck.

Beeeeep.

I swerved, narrowly avoiding drifting into a car in the right lane. My eyes are blurry and my face is wet. I try to wipe it away, but it doesn't stop. It's not fair. He was the best of us. *Is the best of us*. We don't know anything yet.

The two and a half hour drive passed unnoticed.

"Goddamn it," I cursed the impeding labyrinth of the hospital's roads and parking garages. After twenty minutes I found a spot. I took a deep breath, then opened my car door, and stepped out into reality.

"Name of the patient?"

"It's my brother, Calvin Shenk."

"One moment, please."

"Are you aware of what happened?" The drastic change in her tone shook me. Gone was the expedient bureaucratic tone, replaced by one of kindness and empathy. What was meant to be comforting only exacerbated my anxiety.

"I mean, I heard he had a heart attack, but no, I don't really know anything else."

"Why don't you just wait here for a minute honey, while we go grab the social worker. She will give you the details. I am sorry."

"Okay, thank you."

A social worker, what does that mean? News so bad it had to be broken by someone professionally trained to handle the situation.

"Hey, are you the brother of Calvin Shenk?" She was young, smiling, but I could see the pity plastered on her face like a bad cold sore. She was new enough that the years of bearing bad news did not yet come easy. I saw through her like broken glass and the shards cut.

"Why don't you follow me over here into this room, and we can talk about what happened. Are you alone?"

"Yeah, but my sister should be here soon. My parents are on their way too but they are still a couple hours out."

"Great," She said, her voice unnaturally high.

The room was empty except for two chairs and a small table with magazines. The harsh hospital light was more pronounced in the enclosed environment. The blinds on the single window had been shut.

"Would you like to take a seat, or would you rather stand?"

"I'll stand, after a few hours in the car it feels good to be on my feet." I smiled and gave a half hearted chuckle.

"I get that," She said, returning my strained smile.

"..."

"As you have heard, your brother suffered from a cardiac episode,"

"Yeah."

"After a few moments we were able to resuscitate him, but he hasn't not regained consciousness."

"..."

"He is in the ICU right now, we have him hooked up to a ventilator, he still is not breathing on his own."

"Can I see him?" I did not want to see him.

“Yes, I can take you there now if you are ready?” I was not ready.

“Okay.”

We exited the room and walked through the hallway of the Emergency Room. Each room occupied by another nameless sufferer. At the end of the hall she stepped to the right and slid a curtain aside.

I had expected it to be painful, to see my brother like that, but what I saw was not my brother. A lifeless wax figure lay in the bed my brother was supposed to be in, skin white, unmoving, visage obfuscated by a dozen plastic tentacles emanating from every orifice and exposed patch of skin.

“We aren’t sure if he can hear anything but it can be comforting if you would like to talk to him.

What could I say? I love you? I am sorry? No words could do justice to the pain and anger that I felt. My entire life I had defined myself as a problem solver, given any problem or issue, I could always think my way out of it, but there would be no untying or slashing my way through this Gordian Knot. I was powerless. Resigned to stay on the sidelines watching as my brother was slowly broken.

I have always thought it should have been me. I should have been the one with cancer, I should have been the one to get a heart attack, I had done bad things, damnable things, I deserved it, not him.

It was in that moment that I realized for the first time that this was my punishment, forced to watch as the world tore apart the innocent leaving the worst of us to inherit the earth. Death was the release, the reward, for it is only in life that suffering is wrought.